

Path 2 & Path 3, In Depth — and What a "Portfolio" Actually Means

For: Tunisian software-engineering graduate goal: international DJ / music producer. This document goes deep on the two paths closest to being an artist, and then explains the one thing that gates almost every Path-2 application: **the portfolio**.

PART 1 — PATH 2: SOUND DESIGN & PRODUCTION

You make the sound itself

What this field actually is

"Sound design and production" is not one job. It's a family of five, and most programs let you lean toward one or two:

Sub-field	What you actually do	Who pays you
Music production	Write, arrange, record, mix and master records	Artists, labels, yourself
Sound design for picture	Invent and build sounds for film, TV, animation	Studios, post houses
Game audio	Interactive sound — audio that reacts to what a player does	Game studios
Post-production / mixing	Dialogue, foley, balance, final mix, delivery specs	Post houses, studios
Live electronics / performance	Perform electronic music live; build your own instruments	Venues, festivals, yourself

For your DJ/producer goal, **music production** is the core and **live electronics** is the natural second. Game and film audio are where the reliable money is — worth keeping as a door.

What you actually study

A two-year master typically runs like this:

Semester 1 — foundations and levelling-up Critical listening (learning to actually *hear* what's wrong in a mix), studio recording technique, signal flow, synthesis (subtractive, FM, granular, wavetable), sampling, DAW fluency to a professional standard. You'll be pushed out of "bedroom producer" habits fast.

Semester 2 — craft and specialisation Mixing and mastering in depth, arrangement and composition, sound design for a brief (you're given a film scene or game level and must build its entire sound world), spatial/immersive audio (Dolby Atmos, Ambisonics), and usually a collaborative project with film or game students.

Semester 3 — professional practice A large project on your own terms, often an internship or an industry-facing commission. Portfolio building becomes explicit. Many programs bring in working professionals to critique your work.

Semester 4 — final project / thesis A substantial artistic work (an EP, a scored film, an installation, a live performance system) plus written reflection explaining your artistic and technical decisions.

The skill stack you walk out with

Technical - Professional mixing and mastering — the difference between "sounds like a demo" and "sounds like a record" - Synthesis and sound design from first principles: you can *build* a sound rather than hunt for a preset - Recording technique: mic choice and placement, gain staging, room treatment - Spatial audio, increasingly demanded by streaming and games - DAW mastery — Ableton Live, Pro Tools, Reaper — plus Max/MSP and game middleware (Wwise, FMOD)

Creative - Arrangement: how a track holds attention over 6 minutes - A recognisable sonic identity — this is what actually distinguishes a producer - Sound-to-picture storytelling: making sound carry emotion and narrative

Professional - Session workflow, delivery specs, revision rounds, working to a client brief and deadline - Collaboration with directors, artists, game designers - The vocabulary to talk about sound with other professionals — underrated and career-defining

What you end up doing

Music producer · mixing/mastering engineer · sound designer (film, TV, games, advertising) · audio director · technical sound designer (where your coding background becomes a superpower) · live-electronics performer · studio owner.

Money reality, honestly: this is mostly **freelance and project-based**. Income is lumpy — strong months and empty months, especially in the first years. Game and film audio are the most reliably salaried corners; pure music production is the least. Most working producers stack several income streams (client work + sync licensing + their own releases + teaching). Plan for this rather than being surprised by it.

How it serves the DJ/producer goal

This is the most direct path. Concretely, it gives you: - The craft to make your tracks competitive — most aspiring producers plateau on mixing, and this fixes exactly that - Studio and equipment access you could not otherwise afford - A **cohort of collaborators** — the single most underrated benefit; your classmates become your co-producers, your visual artists, the person who books you - Two years living inside a European scene, legally, with time to play and meet people - Critique from professionals — brutal, and the fastest way to improve

Your programs, and the honest entry gates

Program	Where	Funding	Entry gate for YOU
ReSound (Erasmus Mundus)	Dublin Lisbon Vilnius	FULL + €1,400/mo	Easiest strong entry — officially lists "computational science" as an accepted degree
DIGICREA (Erasmus Mundus)	Saint-Étienne Katowice Porto	FULL , zero tuition	Sound-Music specialisation; 3–5 works, max 5 years old
HKU Music Design	Utrecht	Partial (€5,000)	Explicitly accepts non-music bachelors with a strong portfolio
Sonology	The Hague	Partial	Explicitly admits computer-science graduates; portfolio only, no live audition
KASK Ghent (+ Master Mind)	Ghent	FULL via Master Mind	Needs GPA ≥ 3.5/4.0 equivalent
CvA Immersive Audio	Amsterdam	Partial	3 stereo recordings + a live Pro Tools mixing test — hard gate
KCB Live Electronics	Brussels	Partial	Assumes bachelor-level music-tech foundations — hardest gate , likely not yet

Who this path is wrong for

If you need financial stability quickly, or you dislike being judged subjectively on taste, this path will hurt. Your work gets critiqued personally and constantly, and the income is irregular. Go in knowing that.

PART 2 — PATH 3: MUSIC BUSINESS

You build the business around the music

What this industry actually is

Before the degree, understand the money map — it's the thing most artists never learn, and it costs them their careers:

Every song is two separate assets. 1. **The recording (the "master")** — the specific audio file. Usually owned by whoever paid for it: a label, or you. 2. **The composition (the "publishing")** — the underlying melody/lyrics/idea. Owned by the songwriters and their publisher.

When a track plays on Spotify or in a Netflix show, **both** get paid, separately, through different pipelines. Artists who don't know this sign away one of them — often the more valuable one.

Around those two assets sit the industry's sectors:

Sector	What it does	Roles
Recorded music	Labels, distribution, streaming strategy	A&R, label manager, digital strategy
Publishing	Manages song rights, collects royalties	Publisher, royalty analyst, sync agent
Live	Touring, booking, festivals, venues	Booking agent, tour manager, promoter
Management	Runs an artist's whole career	Artist manager
Sync licensing	Places music in film, games, ads (very lucrative)	Sync manager
Brand / digital	Partnerships, social, streaming marketing	Marketing manager

What you actually study

- **Copyright and IP law** — masters vs publishing, splits, moral rights, territory
- **Contracts** — recording, publishing, management, distribution, 360 deals; how to read one and where they hide the traps
- **Royalties and collection** — mechanicals, performance, neighbouring rights, PROs, and why money takes 18 months to arrive
- **Label and A&R operations** — how artists get signed, developed, and dropped
- **Streaming economics** — playlisting, algorithms, pro-rata vs user-centric payouts
- **Live and touring economics** — guarantees, splits, riders, why tours lose money
- **Marketing and artist development** — building an audience deliberately
- **Cultural policy and funding** — public grants and subsidies (large in Europe)

Assessment is essays, case studies, business plans, and usually an **industry internship** — which is often where the actual job comes from.

The skill stack you walk out with

- You can **read a contract** and spot what's being taken from you
- You understand **where every euro comes from** and how to claim it
- You can build a release strategy, a budget, and a marketing plan
- A network of industry contacts — this track is the most network-dense of the three
- Transferable business credentials that work outside music if you need them

What you end up doing

Label roles · artist manager · booking agent · publisher / sync licensing · festival or venue programmer · streaming-platform roles · tour manager · or **running your own label and artist business**.

Money reality: more stable and salaried than Path 2, less than Path 1. Entry-level industry roles pay modestly and are competitive; the money arrives with seniority and, especially, with a roster or a catalogue you own.

How it serves the DJ/producer goal

Indirectly but powerfully. It's the difference between an artist who gets exploited and one who runs a business: - You'd **self-manage** competently — negotiate your own splits, keep your publishing, register your works and actually collect - You'd understand booking, so you can build a touring career rather than wait to be picked - You could run a **small label** for yourself and peers — a very common route for electronic artists - The internship and cohort put you inside the industry, next to bookers and labels

But: it teaches you to run the industry, not to make records. If your bottleneck is that your tracks aren't good enough yet, this path won't fix it.

Your programs — and an important correction

Program	Where	Funding	Note
MIAM — MA Music, Music Business & Management	Istanbul	FULL (Türkiye Bursları)	Best Path-3 option for you — actually music-specific <i>and</i> fully funded, in a 100% English program. Under-30 rule applies.
MA Cultural Management (with Estonian Business School)	Tallinn	FULL (100% tuition scholarship)	Accepts a bachelor's in ANY field — the most accessible funded entry
MAGMa (Erasmus Mundus)	Glasgow Lisbon Paris Rotterdam	FULL	Art market & cultural heritage, <i>not</i> pop-music business; prefers arts/econ/law backgrounds, so you'd be arguing your case
MA Creative Management in New Media (Kieślowski Film School)	Katowice	Full <i>if</i> NAWA Banach won	Media/creative management
Music Business Management MA	UK	Full <i>via Chevening</i>	Pair a UK music-business MA with Chevening funding
Berklee GEMB	Valencia, Spain	Partial	The best-known music-business brand; strong network, but expensive
MA Cultural Economics & Entrepreneurship	Rotterdam	Partial	Rigorous, academic, well-regarded

Correction to earlier advice: I previously flagged MAGMa as your best-funded music-business option. MIAM Istanbul is the better call — it is genuinely *music* business (not arts/heritage), fully funded, taught in English, and your background isn't outside its preferred fields.

Who this path is wrong for

If you want to spend your days making sound, you'll find this frustrating — it's spreadsheets, contracts, essays and email. It's a great *second* skill and a risky *only* skill for someone whose ambition is to be the artist.

PART 3 — WHAT A "PORTFOLIO" ACTUALLY MEANS

This is the single thing that gates Path 2. Get it right and doors open; ignore it and no amount of academic strength saves the application.

What it is — and isn't

A portfolio is evidence that you can make sound, and that you make deliberate decisions.

It is **not** a CV, not a list of software you know, and not "everything I've ever made." Admissions panels are practitioners. They listen for a few minutes and ask one question: *does this person think like an artist, and can we teach them?*

Crucially: **they are not expecting professional-label quality.** They're selecting for potential and intent. A rough but purposeful piece beats a polished but generic one.

What your target programs actually ask for

These are the real published requirements from your shortlist:

Program	The actual spec
ReSound	Max 3 works, 10–15 minutes total, each with a reflective paragraph explaining your role
DIGICREA	Exactly 3–5 works, none older than 5 years, with title, description and public links
Sonology	Compositions, sound installations, live-performance recordings, or research results such as computer programs, articles, theses — plus a 2-page study plan . No live audition.
HKU	Portfolio showing music creation and creative decision-making
CvA Immersive Audio	At least 3 stereo recordings in diverse styles , then interview + on-the-spot Pro Tools mix test
KCB Brussels	CV, audio, video, scores, Max patches, Ableton Live sessions + live performance + interview
REPLAY	Max 5 projects in a 7-page PDF (template given) + 3-minute showreel with a 30-second self-presentation

Notice the pattern: **3–5 pieces, ~10–15 minutes, each explained.** That is the target.

What counts as a "work"

Much broader than "a finished song." Any of these are legitimate:

1. **An original track** — the obvious one. Finished, mixed, intentional.
2. **A sound redesign** — take a film/game/trailer scene, strip its audio, rebuild it entirely. *Extremely common and highly respected* because it shows craft without needing you to compose.

3. **A sound installation or fixed-media piece** — a composed sonic environment, not a song.
4. **A live performance recording** — you performing electronic music, with video.
5. **A game-audio prototype** — interactive sound reacting to player input (Wwise/FMOD/Unity).
6. **An audio tool or instrument you built** — a Max patch, a plugin, a generative system, an ML audio experiment. **Sonology explicitly accepts computer programs. KCB explicitly accepts Max patches.**

The reflective note — where most applicants lose

Every strong portfolio explains each piece in a short paragraph: **intent your role method honest reflection**. For example:

"Concrete Ground" (3:40, original track, 2026) I wanted to build a piece where the rhythm comes entirely from non-musical sources, so I recorded metal, concrete and water around Tunis and used them as the whole percussion kit. I wrote, recorded, produced and mixed it alone. The samples were processed with granular synthesis in Ableton, using a Max patch I wrote to randomise grain position over time. The low end is the weak point — the sub competes with the kick — and it's what I most want to learn to fix.

Why this works: it shows a **concept**, your **exact role**, a **method** (with your technical edge visible), and **self-critique** — which is the clearest signal that you're teachable.

What kills applications

- Covers or remixes with no original contribution
- Loops and unfinished sketches — always submit *finished* pieces, however short
- 20 tracks that all sound the same — they asked for 3–5, obey it
- No explanation of what you actually did (especially in collaborations)
- Dead or private links — test every link from a logged-out browser
- Chasing polish over ideas — a distinctive rough piece beats a generic clean one

Your unfair advantage

Most applicants to these programs are musicians who can't code. **You can.** Your database shows this is explicitly valued:

- **Sonology** accepts *computer programs* as portfolio works and admits CS graduates outright
- **ReSound** names *computational science* as an accepted degree
- **KCB** accepts *Max patches and Ableton sessions* as portfolio material
- **DIGICREA** sits at the art/tech/science intersection by design

So do not hide the engineering — **make it the through-line**. A portfolio built around "I build systems that generate and transform sound" is far more memorable than another folder of house tracks. It gives you a *voice*, which is exactly what panels select for.

A concrete 6-month build plan

You have until roughly **November 2026 – February 2027**. That's enough for a strong portfolio of 4 pieces if you start now.

Month	Build
Aug 2026	Piece 1 — original track. Finish something. Your best existing idea, completed and mixed properly. Finishing is the skill.
Sep 2026	Piece 2 — sound redesign. Pick a 90-second film/game/trailer scene, mute it, rebuild every sound. Shows craft fast. (<i>IELTS this month too.</i>)
Oct 2026	Piece 3 — the code piece. Your differentiator: a generative system, a Max patch, a custom instrument, or an ML audio experiment — plus a short piece made <i>with</i> it.
Nov 2026	Piece 4 — original track #2, contrasting. Different tempo/mood, to show range. Write the reflective notes for all four.
Dec 2026	Package it: host, write descriptions, build the PDF, get feedback, re-mix the weakest piece.
Jan–Feb 2027	Tailor per application (ReSound wants ≤15 min; DIGICREA wants 3–5 works) and submit.

How to package it

- **Host audio** on private/unlisted SoundCloud or Bandcamp; **video** on unlisted Vimeo/YouTube
- **One PDF** — for each piece: title, year, duration, role, the reflective paragraph, and the link
- **Name files properly:** `01_Concrete-Ground_original-track.pdf`, not `final_v3_REAL.wav`
- **Lead with your strongest piece.** Panels often stop after the first two.
- **Test every link logged out** before submitting

PART 4 — CAN YOU DO BOTH?

Yes, and for your specific goal it's the smart play:

1. **MIAM Istanbul** offers *both* Sonic Arts / Sound Engineering **and** Music Business & Management concentrations, fully funded. One application, both worlds.
2. **Study Path 2, self-teach Path 3.** The business knowledge that matters most to a working artist — rights, splits, royalties, contracts — is genuinely learnable from books and courses. The craft in Path 2 is not; it needs studios, mentors and critique.
3. **Path 3 programs with an entrepreneurship angle** (Estonian Academy, Sibelius Global Music) are built for artists who run their own careers.

My recommendation for you

Lead with Path 2, and keep one funded Path-3 application as insurance.

- **Primary:** ReSound DIGICREA HKU / Sonology (*Path 2, and your degree qualifies*)
- **Insurance:** MIAM Istanbul (*covers both tracks, fully funded*) and Estonian Academy (*any-degree entry, full tuition scholarship*)
- **Non-negotiable either way: IELTS by September 2026 and 4 portfolio pieces by December 2026**

Path 3 will always be learnable later, from books and from doing. Path 2's craft is what a funded two years in a European studio buys you — and it's the thing that actually makes the tracks good enough for the rest to matter.